Harmony and Voice Leading: Study Notes

Subject: Triad Qualities, Inversions, SATB Part Writing, and Cadences

Chapter 1: Triad Construction and Inversions

A triad consists of three tones stacked in thirds above a fundamental root tone: the root, third, and fifth.

The Four Triad Qualities:
1. **Major Triad:** Root, Major 3rd (4 semitones), Perfect 5th (7 semitones). Example: C – E – G.
2. **Minor Triad:** Root, Minor 3rd (3 semitones), Perfect 5th (7 semitones). Example: A – C – E, D – F – A.
3. **Diminished Triad:** Root, Minor 3rd (3 semitones), Diminished 5th (6 semitones). Example: B – D – F. Note: Contains a diminished fifth, NOT a perfect fifth.
4. **Augmented Triad:** Root, Major 3rd (4 semitones), Augmented 5th (8 semitones). Example: C – E – G#.

Inversions & Figured Bass:
• **Root Position (5/3):** Root in bass. Denoted I, V, IV.
• **First Inversion (6/3 or 6):** Third of chord in bass. Intervals above bass are a 3rd and 6th. Denoted I6, V6, ii6.
• **Second Inversion (6/4):** Fifth of chord in bass. Intervals above bass are a 4th and 6th. Denoted I6/4 (cadential 6/4).

Chapter 2: SATB Voice Leading Laws

Four-part choral writing utilizes Soprano, Alto, Tenor, and Bass voices (SATB). Good voice leading preserves melodic contour and independence.

Strict Prohibition of Consecutive Parallel Fifths and Octaves:
In classical four-part SATB writing, consecutive parallel fifths and parallel octaves between any two voices are strictly prohibited. When two voices move in parallel motion by fifths or octaves, their independent acoustic identity is destroyed. Part writers prevent parallel motion primarily by employing contrary motion (voices moving in opposite directions).

Leading Tone Resolution: The leading tone (^7) possesses a strong upward melodic tendency and must resolve upward by step to the tonic (^1), particularly in outer soprano/bass voices.

Chapter 3: Harmonic Cadences and Progressions

A cadence punctuates musical phrases and articulates formal structure.

The Four Core Cadence Types:
1. **Perfect Authentic Cadence (PAC):** Dominant to Tonic progression (V to I). Both chords must be in root position, and the soprano voice must finish on the tonic root (^1). This is the most conclusive cadence in tonal music.
2. **Imperfect Authentic Cadence (IAC):** V to I cadence where either chord is inverted (e.g. V6 to I), or the soprano ends on scale degree ^3 or ^5.
3. **Half Cadence (HC):** Pauses on the Dominant chord (V), preceded by I, ii, or IV. It leaves the phrase open and expectant.
4. **Deceptive Cadence (DC):** The dominant V resolves unexpectedly to the submediant vi (or VI in minor), interrupting expected tonic arrival.

Dominant Seventh (V7) Voice Leading: In resolving V7 to I: the leading tone (3rd of V7) resolves up by step to ^1; the chordal 7th resolves down by step to ^3; the 5th steps down to ^1; and the bass root leaps from ^5 to ^1.